

Education Session #9

Behavioral Deep Dive



- Casing feedback
- Why is the fit/ behavioral interview important?
- Behavioral Interview Structure (including PEI)
- Tips & Pitfalls
- **Breakout:** Observe an MBA2 and practice your stories

Casing Feedback: Don't forget about delivery & presentation

Casing is just as much about how you present yourself as it is your ability to solve the case.

- 1. Be excited to solve the case:** Consulting work will be similar to casing. You should be having fun with it! Practice showing off your excitement in your mock interviews – if you're not practicing it, you won't do it on interview day.
- 2. Pay attention to tone inflection:** This will keep your interviewer engaged and excited to work with you by keeping your energy high
- 3. Speak with confidence:** Consultants often have to solve ambiguous problems in industries they've never worked in before. Your goal in the case interview will be to show that you can be confident in many different client situations.
- 4. Be creative:** Avoid ubiquitous scripted language such as "let me take a moment to structure my thoughts" or re-reading the prompt word-for-word. Be more creative here and put this language in your own voice!

Fit interview - Perceptions & Reality

I can just wing it

You need be prepared to come across confident, structured and likeable

Casing is more important than behavioral

No, casing is extremely important, but you also need to pass the behavioral!

I know my background well, so I don't need to prepare for Behavioral Interviews

The prep you did to get into Ross will help you, but it doesn't stop there

I need prepare answers for all questions I might be asked

It is much more efficient to develop several stories(5-7) that can answer a variety of questions that are focused on the hiring criteria

Consultants have a lot of industry experience, so I can use industry jargon

Don't use jargon; highlight impact + your why + your skills

Consultants aren't from my industry, so I need to explain what I did in each of my roles

Don't get lost in the weeds; highlight consulting skills

- **Past behavior** when challenged or stressed is (somewhat) **indicative of future behavior**
- How you've **handled challenges**
- Present your background in a **structured manner**
- **Do not discount this part of the interview!** Firms would not waste their time on it if the case was the only thing that mattered
- What to practice: Odyssey, Why Consulting, Why This Firm; Choose the right work experiences to share

The first question of a fit interview is typically broad and open-ended (Think of it as a warm-up)

So, tell me about yourself...

THIS IS THE TIME FOR YOUR ODYSSEY! (A firm will not ask "give me your Odyssey")

- A great odyssey sets the tone for all your answers to follow-ups and focused questions
- **GOAL: tell your story and connect the dots between your jobs, college experience, and why you are interested in consulting. A good odyssey will have interesting points that will get follow up questions.**

TIPS

- On average it will last ~2 minutes
- Think of this as the plot summary of a movie – what are the high-level points that define you
- **Focus on why** you made certain moves in terms that people not familiar with your industry/background can understand
- **Write it out and practice but do not turn into a robot!!!**
- More than just a recital of resume – adds the context of why, passions you have, etc.
- General, but able to be tailor for different firms and other career paths



The fit interview also allows the interviewer to learn about your specific interests in their firm and in consulting in general

Why Consulting? Why us?

- It's important to firms that they recruit professionals who have been thoughtful in their decisions
- The amount of research/face time you have put in with the firm will come through in these questions
- You should have **specific reasons** as to why you want to pursue Consulting over another field, and why you are interested in the firms you are interviewing for

TIPS for "why this firm?"

Utilize prior research on the firm to customize this response to whoever you are interviewing with.

- **Connect your specific career interests** with certain practices within the firm/recent projects the firm has engaged in. ***This is the most important of the four bullets here!!!**
- Reference **specific conversations/interactions** you have had with individuals from the firm throughout recruiting events on campus
- **Make it personal** – factor in life considerations, such as office location, travel schedule, staffing model, family/partner perks, etc. into your consideration for their firm
- Consider **firm culture, professional development approach (specialization vs. Generalist), staffing model (office-based vs. National)** when thinking about this answer

What kinds of questions will I be asked?

- There are many resources / questions banks you can reference for behavioral interviews. They include:
 - [Behavioral Spreadsheet](#)
 - [CDO Guide to Sample Interview Questions](#)
- McKinsey PEI is slightly different – but the prep you do for all your behaviorals will be applicable



McKinsey Behavioral Interview: PEI

If you're interviewing with McKinsey, they will give you the PEI questions in advance. All questions they will ask (word-for-word) are listed [HERE](#).

How are PEI's different?

- **Length:** You'll be expected to have one story per question that will take ~10 minutes to tell
- **Weight:** PEI's are weighed very heavily at McKinsey – so spend time preparing for them!
- **Structure:** You should plan to give a brief overview of the story and check with the interviewer that the story is a good fit. Have a back up planned if they say no. McKinsey also follows the STAR format: Situation, Task, Action, Result.
- **Follow up Questions:** You may be asked to expand on parts of your story or dive deeper in a direction you weren't expecting – know every aspect of your story and be able to speak to it (and always share honest stories – they'll know if you're making things up as you go)
- **Impact:** Choose stories where you had a tangible impact (it doesn't have to be a big impact) and can show personal growth

If you want more information or help preparing, book a PEI mock interview through Ross Recruit or email an MBA2 who interned at McKinsey!

What makes a great behavioral answer

- **Structured:** Follow the CAR format so you give the interviewer just enough **context** to follow along, get to the **action** of the story, and follow up with the **results** and, if applicable, your **learning**.
- **Personal:** Only you have lived your experiences. This is your chance to own them and have your interviewer get to know you better. Avoid making it look like you're infallible
- **Interesting:** Make sure your story has some tension (but please remember it should still be professional) - but make it interesting to listen to and follow along. This includes being sure you're not using tons of industry jargon your interviewer won't know.
- **What not to do:** Badmouth others, over OR undershare, spend 90 seconds on context. Be human!

*CDO's
3-step
guide*

Identify the theme of the question

What key attribute/skill is the interviewer trying to assess? Conflict resolution? Leadership? Teamwork?

Think strategically

How do you want to phrase your answer? What emotions do you want to present? What skills do you want to highlight?

Manage the message!

What key takeaways do you want the interviewer to have? (for eg – how do you want them to describe you as a leader?)

How do you prepare?

1. **Brainstorm:** Start by thinking about all of your experiences – just like MBA applications, your examples don't have to all come from work experience (but most should)
2. **Cull the list:** Start to pull out your 6 –8 best stories and organize them by theme (note some stories may apply to multiple themes - that's ok as long as you don't give them to the same firm)
3. **Create Names / Stories:** Create a summary of the story that takes ~10 seconds to say, so you can recall the important elements of the story on interview day in case you get a bit lost as you talk.
4. **Practice**, practice, practice! Say them out loud as you're on a walk, in the shower, on a call with a friend. Highly value feedback when you receive it and work on incorporating it into your story.
5. **Add on:** Think about follow up questions that could be asked at various stages of your stories and prep answers

Deep Dive on ACTION:

Action is the most important part of your story. It should...

- Answer the question of “**how will this person behave when this situation arises in the future?**”
- Take up the most time
- Be structured! (1-2-3 format)
- Delineate “Rinse and Repeat” actions

Smarak’s example

Context: I was asked to reduce costs by 12% without impacting market share

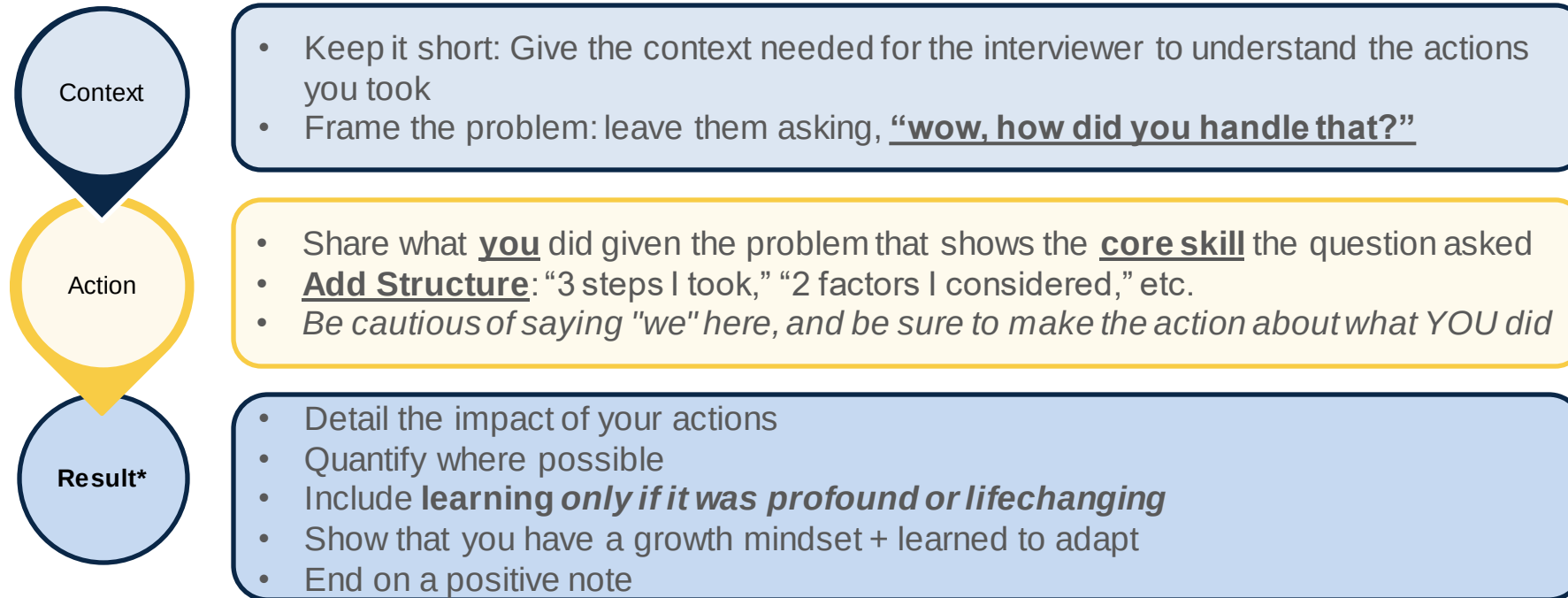
Action: In reaction to this I...

1. Made spend-waterfall, and looked at cost heads that had low ROI
2. Met one-on-one with the team members who would be impacted by budget cuts, and looked at ways to reappropriate spends to preserve revenue
3. Started with pilots to observe impact on a controlled scale

Result: I was able to design a model that resulted in a 13.6% cost reduction and still helped org increase market share by 1.2%



Actions are repeatable
Communication is clearly structured
Interviewer can understand exactly what made you successful



*It's ok to include a profound (e.g. - life changing learning) in your result, but you need not include a learning in all of your answers. **Their primary interest is how you will handle similar challenging situations in the future**



Spend most of your time on “Action” to show how your actions were critical to success; use first-person and action-based language



- Questions to workshop:
 - Failure
 - New Initiative
 - Lead through Conflict
 - Success
- For each of the behavioral questions:
 - everyone gets 1-2 minutes to workshop the story
 - 3 volunteers answer in front of the full group (max 2 mins. per story)
- MBA2 to provide feedback on each of the stories

Next Steps

Behavioral Stories

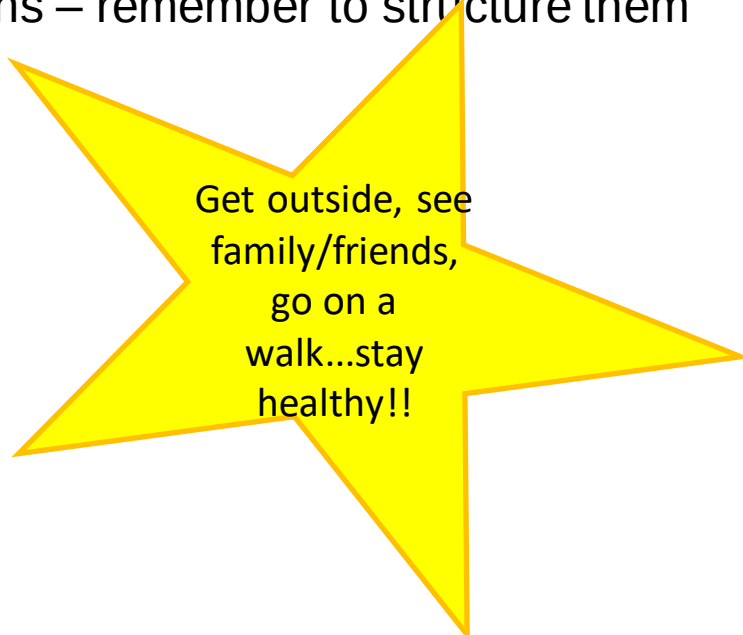
- **Check out** the themes in the behavioral template and look through the sample questions
- **Prepare stories** that can be used to answer one or more of these questions – remember to structure them using the CAR format

Practice your Behaviorals

- **Schedule a practice behavioral interview** with FACT group leader after Thanksgiving
- **Practice your responses** OUT LOUD by yourself or with classmates

Don't forget your Cases!

- **Continue to reflect on your mock case interviews**, keep your case tracker updated and start to hone in on your areas of weakness – this is where your focus should be now!



Get outside, see
family/friends,
go on a
walk...stay
healthy!!

Happy Thanksgiving!! & Please fill out the Pulse Survey!

